RED TEGU

Salvator rufescens

What can I see or hear?

A reddish, heavy-bodied lizard up to 4 to 5 feet. Forked tongue flicks the air. Powerful jaws, blunt teeth for crushing. Diurnal — active by day, basking in sun.

Where does it live, and why?

Temperate Chaco and Espinal of central South America. Burrows by habit. Brumates underground for up to 7 months in cold periods. Burrows are thermal refuge.

How does it send messages?

Body posture, tongue-flicks (reading scent), tail movement. Hisses and puffs when threatened. Recognizes individual handlers by scent and sight.

What does it do when something changes?

Brumates — buries in and stays largely dormant through cold months. During reproductive season, raises body temperature several degrees ABOVE its burrow.

How does it learn?

Highly intelligent for a reptile — solves problems, recognizes people, learns target-and-reward training. Investigates new objects with the tongue.

How does it have babies?

Female builds a nest, lays around 30 eggs, and aggressively guards it. Eggs hatch in 120 to 170 days. Hatchlings are 8 inches long and self-sufficient at hatch.

What are the limits?

Lifespan 15 to 20 years. Cold below ~50°F shuts them down. Cannot tolerate captivity without burrows, basking heat, and varied protein.

What does this teach us?

A cold-blooded animal that bends the rules — generates its own heat to protect eggs. Animals are not locked into one rulebook; environment selects for whatever works.

Think About This

When the rules don't fit, do you bend them or break?

What a living thing can sense becomes its reality. Environment shapes design.